FINE LIVING

HOTEL

THE SANCTUARY POUR

On a heritage coffee estate in the Western Ghats, The Leela has built its most soulful address yet. I went looking for stillness and found a masterclass in flavour, from the cupping table to the cocktail glass to the hammam's warm marble.

Sandeep Arora
Founder, Spiritual Luxury Living

I have spent much of my life with my nose in a glass. Spirits have taught me that flavour is a story of place: the water, the soil, the weather and the hands that shape it. So when I drove up into the Western Ghats to The Leela Coorg Forest Sanctuary, I expected beautiful scenery. I did not expect a coffee bean to sharpen my palate.

Kodagu, as locals call Coorg, has always lived at its own unhurried pace—a land wrapped in mist, punctuated by hills, tumbling waterfalls and endless plantations, where coffee, pepper and cardamom have shaped both the economy and the rhythm of daily life.

Deep in the heart of this landscape, The Leela Coorg Forest Sanctuary—unveiled as the toast of the group, which celebrates 40 years of Indian luxury—is less a label than an expression of intent. Luxury here is nature-led and wellness-forward, where the forest sets the pace and restoration is the point. Spread across 76 acres near Madikeri on one of Coorg's oldest coffee estates, the team has had the good sense not to tidy that heritage away. Arabica and robusta still grow between the villas, pepper vines twist up towering silver oaks, and fig trees drop their fruit onto the paths. At the heart of it lies a seven-acre lake, perfectly still on misty mornings.

The architecture is quiet and assured. Red brick, bamboo and timber are folded into the hillside so gently that the forest always feels like the main event. The property holds IGBC Platinum green certification, and its 71 villas, soon to grow to 90, range from duplex and family villas to pool villas with temperature-controlled water. The crowning Sunbeam Presidential Villa has four bedrooms and its own wellness facilities, and a private helipad awaits guests who prefer to skip the drive. After decades of palaces and grand city hotels, this is The Leela speaking in a softer voice, and it suits the brand beautifully.